GRADE 12 / English HL / English

Build a defensible literary paragraph

01 Understand

Learning goals: Make an interpretive claim • Integrate concise textual evidence • Explain form and meaning together

A literary response develops a reading of a text. Start with a precise claim that can be defended using its language or structure.

Evidence must be followed by analysis: explain what a word, contrast, image or structural choice contributes to meaning.

For prescribed literature, use the school's current text and edition. This original short poem is skills practice and is not presented as a prescribed poem.

Original poem: "I fold the map. / The road remains. / Beyond the gate, / the morning waits."

Detail	Interpretive possibility	Support
fold the map	less reliance on planning	an action ends preparation
road remains	uncertainty continues	contrast with folded map
morning waits	new possibility	personification and open ending

02 Follow the reasoning

Write a paragraph explaining how the poem presents beginning a journey.

1. Claim: the poem presents beginning as a choice to act despite uncertainty.

2. Evidence: folding the map ends preparation, but "the road remains", showing that the journey is still ahead.

3. Analysis: the personified morning "waits" makes possibility feel available; the open ending does not guarantee success.

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Practise with purpose

03 Try before checking

Use paper or your notebook. Show your reasoning. For written responses, use evidence and explain your choices. Suggested time: 15–20 minutes.

1. Identify one example of personification.

2. Explain the contrast between the first two lines.

3. Why is “the speaker will definitely succeed” too strong?

04 Check and correct

1. “The morning waits.”

2. The map can be folded and preparation ended, but the actual road and journey still exist.

3. The poem offers possibility but gives no outcome; that claim exceeds its evidence.

Common mistake to avoid

Distinguish speaker from poet, and interpret from evidence rather than treating every image as having one fixed meaning.

Reflect and revisit

Identify one correction in your own words. Attempt a similar question tomorrow without looking at the guide. If you are still unsure, take your attempt to a teacher or tutor.

Coverage and sources

CAPS topic focus: Reading and viewing: literary response; writing and presenting

DBE CAPS, Grades 10–12: English. Section 3 content and skills. This is a focused supplement, not a complete syllabus or prescribed literature replacement.

Open the official DBE curriculum reference

Content and visuals: original SmartBridge FET. AI-assisted authoring; subject-teacher and language-specialist review pending. Report an issue with the pack ID enhl-12.